



Holiday spirit

US Marines sit down to celebrate their first Tet holiday (Vietnamese New Year) on base in January 1965. Their meal, which included fresh fruits and cold beer, was prepared by local women.

Out of danger

The majority of US personnel in Vietnam served in support capacities, as mechanics, drivers, cooks, and clerks. For those stationed on large rearward bases, their war was a far cry from the mud, dust, and constant danger of fire support bases, remote radio outposts, and especially combat patrols. Poor morale among the troops was a persistent problem, and commanders often addressed it by trying to make life on base more comfortable. These efforts had the opposite effect: soldiers furthest in the rear, where life was more comfortable, had lower morale than soldiers in forward areas, where combat provided a sense of urgency and purpose. The disparity between bases also engendered resentments. Combat troops passing through these installations recognized that support troops risked little—yet received the same combat pay—and enjoyed far superior living conditions.

The abundance on display in American PXs, open mess clubs, and even individual soldiers' quarters did not only upset other US personnel. The largesse was particularly shocking to displaced Vietnamese people nearby—many of whom worked menial jobs on base, and fashioned their homes and meals from American garbage.

BEER eased tension and quenched thirst. Budweiser was the No. 1 seller on base but soldiers also drank the local "33" (Ba Muoi Ba).